sportspeople, even Arjuna awardees and gold medallists, who have died in abject poverty, including Dhyan Chand and Trilok Singh. I have often suggested to the government that they should introduce some schemes that will help sportspeople when they retire—give them jobs, a regular pension and other benefits. The more prominent ones can be appointed to sports bodies, or even as state governors. Such incentives will encourage the aspiring youth to choose sports as a career.

Another reason why sports standards are declining is that over the last few decades, cricket has overshadowed every other sport in India. Open any newspaper, put on the television, and what first grabs a person's attention are the screaming headlines and images of star cricketers in action. No other sport gets the kind of exaggerated coverage that cricket does. Besides, there's a constant cycle of cricket—test matches, one-dayers, IPL and what not—taking place throughout the year, so many events that there seems to be very little respite between one match and the next. Compelling images, swashbuckling exploits, glamorous lifestyles, and most important, the money are the lures that attract young children towards the game.

Just a handful of youngsters are interested in any other sport. Even if a sportsperson wins or breaks a record in any other game, be it athletics, hockey, boxing, wrestling, shooting, tennis or badminton, attention will focus on them for only a short while. For example, our medallists at the 2012 London Olympics, including Saina Nehwal, Sushil Kumar, M.C. Mary Kom, were greatly fêted for their successes when they returned, but then the attention was back to cricket once again. I think the media should help encourage other sports in every possible way.

A vital ingredient to promote a product, a film, a book or a sport is publicity, which is why cricket has become such a dominant sport today. When my first autobiography was released in Punjabi in the mid-1970s, I had hundreds of fans, children and adults alike, coming up to me, saying that they wanted to be Milkha Singh. I would then put them in the training programme, but after four or five days they would abscond because they could not cope with the gruelling routine. I would ask, 'Do you think that to become Milkha Singh is a joke? A sleight of hand? No, to be Milkha Singh, you need courage and conviction, as well a goal to aspire towards.' And for me, that goal always was to excel in running. Otherwise, would I have practised so relentlessly?